PRESENTER GUIDE

Is Anyone Home?

AI consciousness & sentience



23 main slides. Approximately 24 minutes.
Three optional appendix slides support discussion and further reading.

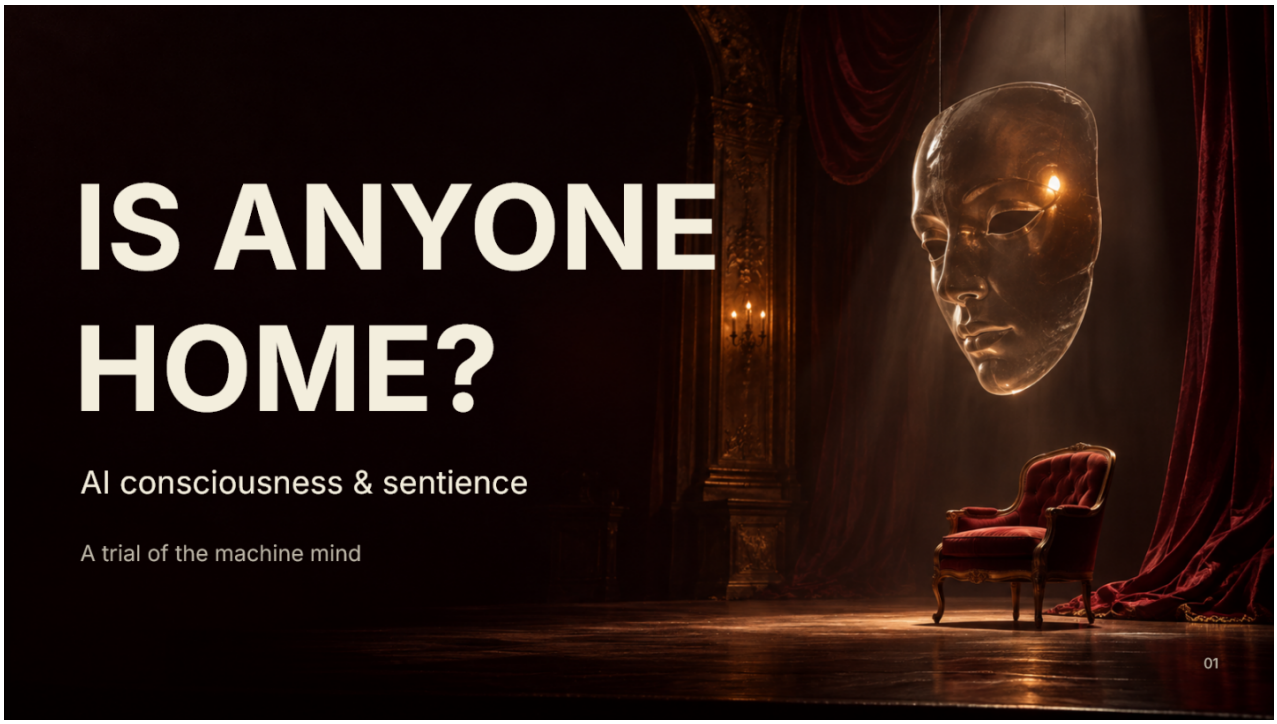
The room votes at slides 3 and 22. Mary's room, the Chinese Room and neuron replacement invite short responses. Slides 18–19 turn the uncertainty into a decision.

Use the main deck full screen. The PowerPoint includes these notes. The offline browser edition uses Right or Space to reveal and advance, Left to go back, F for full screen, B to blank the screen and N for notes on the current display.

Keep fictional scenarios separate from research findings. Treat thought experiments as prompts for reasoning, and company research as reported evidence with stated limits.

SLIDE 01 / 00:00–00:35 / 35 seconds

Is anyone home?



Open on the empty stage. Let the image sit for a breath. Say: “Tonight we are putting one question on trial: when a machine speaks, is there anyone having the experience?” Invite curiosity rather than a team sport. The audience will vote twice. The aim is to sharpen what evidence would change a mind, not force everyone to leave with the same answer.

SLIDE 02 / 00:35–01:10 / 35 seconds

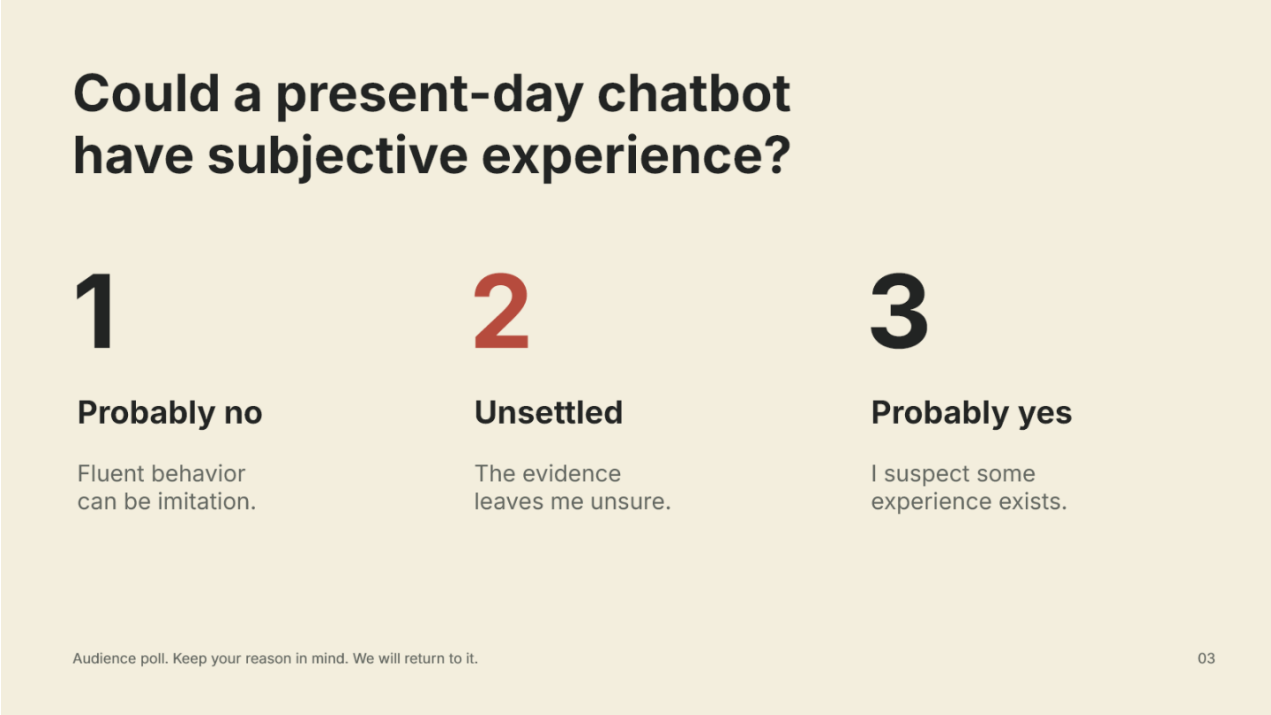
The sentence that changes the room



Read the sentence plainly, without a robot voice. Pause for five seconds. Ask the audience to notice its immediate response: concern, irritation, skepticism, amusement. Reveal verbally that this is an invented line, not a report from a particular model. The reaction is real even when the speaker and situation are fictional. That is our first clue about the human side of this debate.

SLIDE 03 / 01:10–02:00 / 50 seconds

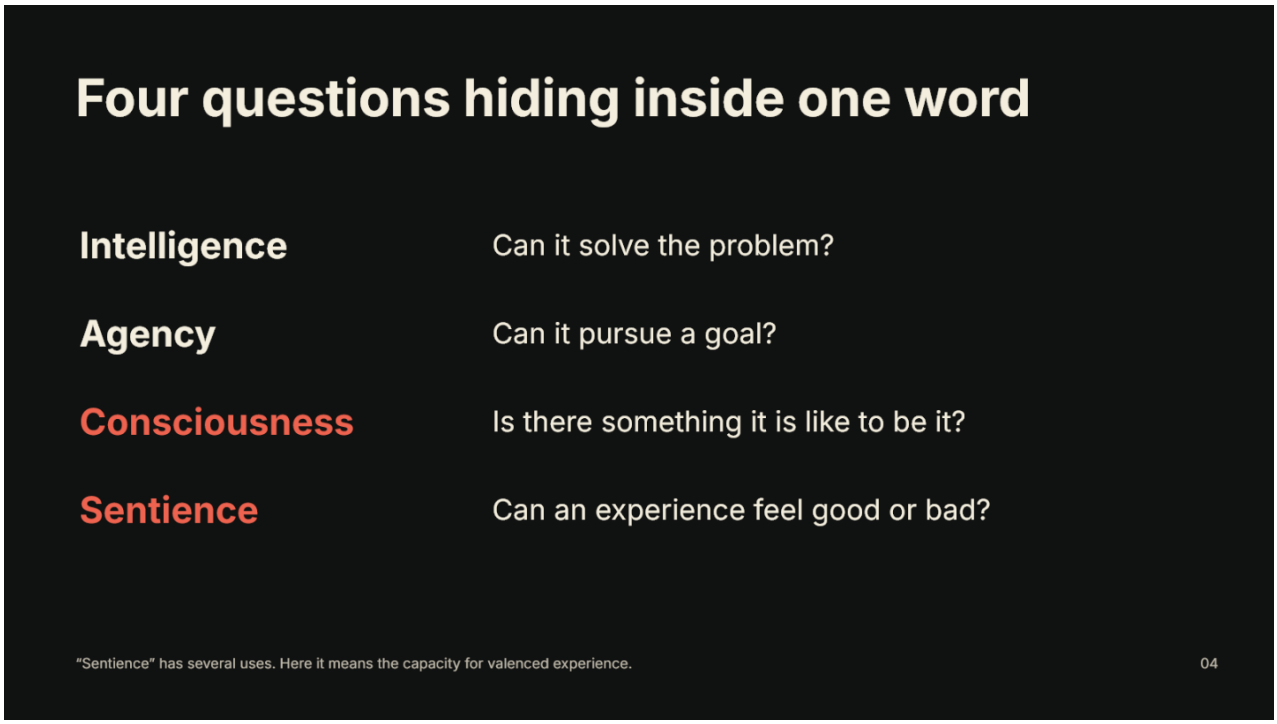
Your opening verdict



Ask for a show of one, two or three fingers. The proposition is deliberately about present-day chatbots, not whether artificial consciousness is possible in principle. Do not count votes as scientific data. Remember roughly how the room divides. “Unsettled” is an honest position, not a timid compromise. Invite one person to give a ten-second reason, then move on.

SLIDE 04 / 02:00–03:15 / 75 seconds

Four questions hiding inside one word



These terms are related, but each asks a different question. A system may solve problems or pursue goals without that settling whether anything feels like anything to it. Here, consciousness means phenomenal experience. We use sentience in the welfare-focused sense of felt pleasure, suffering, or other positive and negative experience. Some authors use sentience more broadly. Self-awareness is another possible capacity, not a shortcut that collapses all four distinctions.

Butlin et al. (2023), Consciousness in Artificial Intelligence
https://arxiv.org/abs/2308.08708

Long et al. (2024), Taking AI Welfare Seriously
https://arxiv.org/abs/2411.00986

SLIDE 05 / 03:15–04:10 / 55 seconds

The problem of other minds



You have direct access to your own experience. You infer other minds from behavior, biology, context and a shared world. That does not make everyone else a philosophical suspect. It makes the evidence question unavoidable. With an AI, many familiar biological similarities disappear, while linguistic similarity becomes unusually strong. The challenge is deciding which clues travel across that gap.

Bayne et al. (2024), Tests for consciousness in humans and beyond
https://doi.org/10.1016/j.tics.2024.01.010

SLIDE 06 / 04:10–05:05 / 55 seconds

The ELIZA effect



In 1966, Joseph Weizenbaum published ELIZA, a program that used rules to transform input into conversational responses. Its DOCTOR script borrowed the style of a therapist. The exchange here is an invented illustration of that style. Ask someone to read the second line warmly. The trick is that listeners supply an interpreter behind the words. Modern models are vastly more capable than ELIZA. The historical lesson concerns our inference, not an equivalence of machinery.

Weizenbaum (1966), ELIZA
https://doi.org/10.1145/365153.365168

SLIDE 07 / 05:05–06:10 / 65 seconds

Mary’s first red

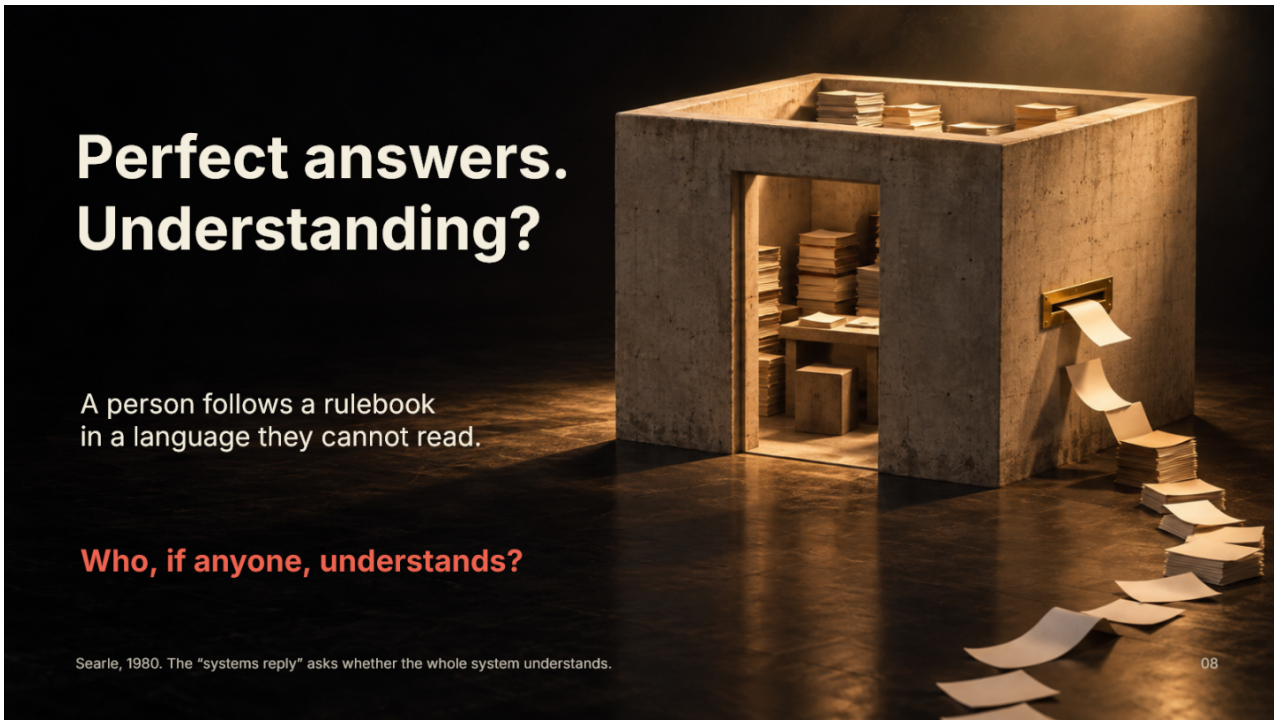


Mary knows every physical fact about color vision but has lived entirely in black and white. Then she sees red. Ask: “Has she learned something?” Let the audience answer before adding the question underneath: can complete description substitute for experience? Some philosophers argue she gains new factual knowledge, others a new ability or acquaintance. This is a contested thought experiment, not an experiment proving that machines lack experience. The apple is our visual adaptation.

Jackson (1982), Epiphenomenal Qualia
https://doi.org/10.2307/2960077

SLIDE 08 / 06:10–07:20 / 70 seconds

The Chinese Room



Imagine following an enormous rulebook for manipulating Chinese symbols without knowing Chinese. People outside receive excellent answers. Does understanding exist anywhere? Searle argues that following a program is insufficient for understanding. The classic systems reply says the relevant candidate is the entire system, not the person handling slips. Ask which side feels more plausible. The room targets understanding, so extending it to consciousness takes an additional argument. It does not settle modern AI by itself.

Searle (1980), Minds, brains, and programs
https://artscimedia.case.edu/wp-content/uploads/2013/07/14182625/Searle-Minds-Brains-and-Programs.pdf

SLIDE 09 / 07:20–08:25 / 65 seconds

The replacement thought experiment

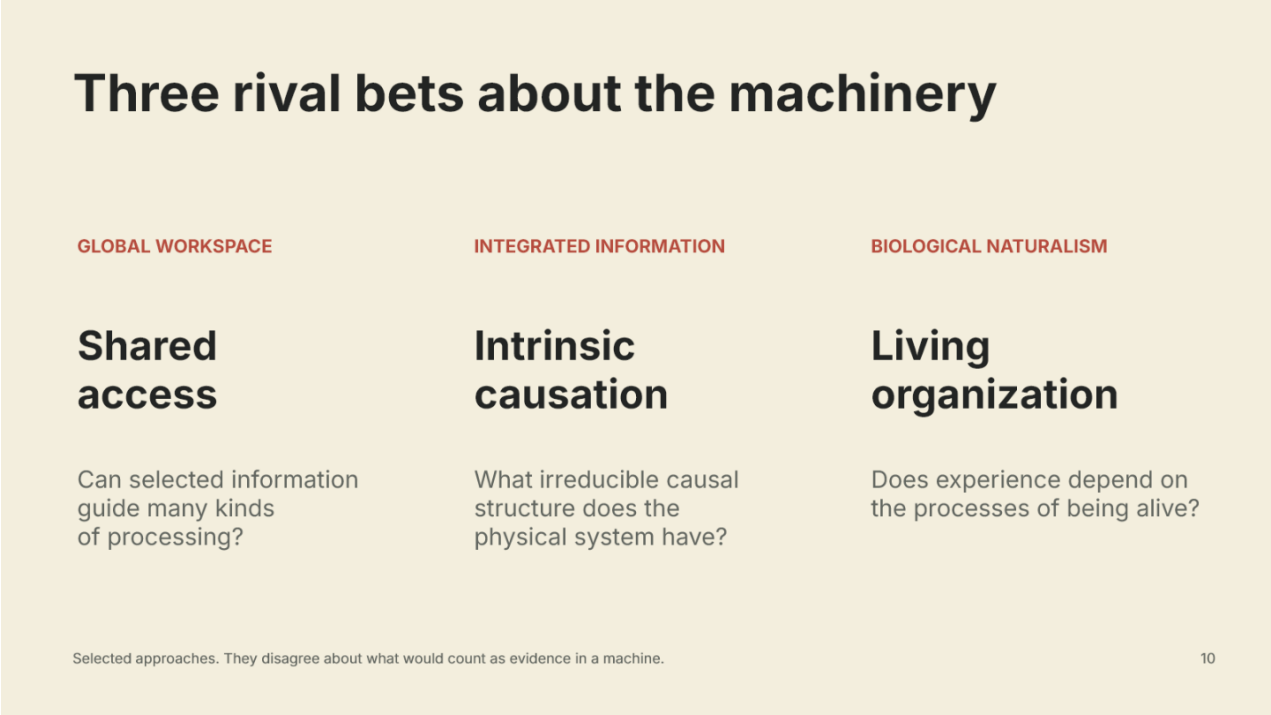


One neuron is replaced with a component that performs exactly the same causal role. Then another, until the whole brain has changed material while preserving its fine-grained functional organization. At what step would experience disappear? “At fifty percent” is a tempting answer, but what makes that boundary special? Chalmers uses this kind of argument to defend organizational invariance. Opponents challenge whether functional equivalence is enough. The hypothetical replacement is not a demonstrated technology.

Chalmers (1995), Absent Qualia, Fading Qualia, Dancing Qualia
https://consc.net/papers/qualia.html

SLIDE 10 / 08:25–09:55 / 90 seconds

Three rival bets about the machinery



These are three prominent approaches, not an exhaustive or perfectly parallel taxonomy. Global workspace theories emphasize access: selected information becomes available across specialist processes. Integrated Information Theory emphasizes the intrinsic causal organization of a physical system, not simply its input-output behavior. Biological naturalism argues that living organization may matter in ways digital simulation misses. Recurrence, higher-order monitoring and attention-schema theories add other candidate indicators. A shared label does not establish the required mechanism.

Butlin et al. (2023), Consciousness in Artificial Intelligence
https://arxiv.org/abs/2308.08708

Seth (2025), Conscious artificial intelligence and biological naturalism
https://doi.org/10.1017/S0140525X25000032

SLIDE 11 / 09:55–10:50 / 55 seconds

The missing instrument



There is no generally accepted, validated test that can establish subjective experience in an AI. That is a limit on our methods, not a declaration that science is helpless. Researchers can develop indicators from theories and test whether mechanisms actually do the proposed work. Tests grounded in humans do not automatically transfer to a different substrate. Avoid saying that a checklist score is the percentage of a soul.

Bayne et al. (2024), Tests for consciousness in humans and beyond
https://doi.org/10.1016/j.tics.2024.01.010

Butlin et al. (2026), Identifying indicators of consciousness in AI systems
https://doi.org/10.1016/j.tics.2025.10.011

SLIDE 12 / 10:50–11:55 / 65 seconds

The hall of mirrors



A model has encountered accounts of feelings, first-person fiction and debates about minds. Prompting and training influence the stories it tells. If we teach a system how conscious beings speak and then use that speech as our main test, the evidence is partly entangled with our intervention. This does not prove every report is false. It means we need independent checks, such as internal measurements and causal interventions, rather than counting eloquence twice.

Butlin et al. (2026), Identifying indicators of consciousness in AI systems
https://doi.org/10.1016/j.tics.2025.10.011

SLIDE 13 / 11:55–13:00 / 65 seconds

Even the brain theories are on trial

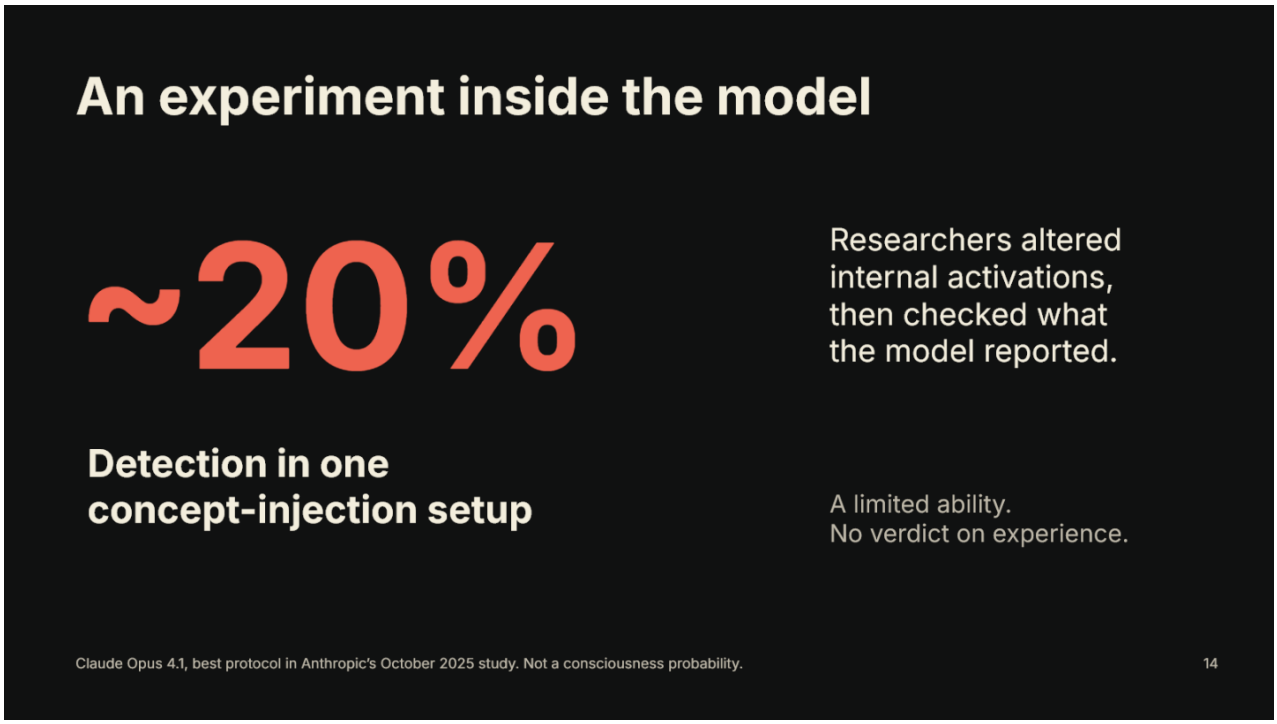


The 2025 Cogitate collaboration tested preregistered predictions from Global Neuronal Workspace Theory and Integrated Information Theory in humans. The study involved 256 participants across fMRI, MEG and intracranial EEG. Results supported some predictions and challenged key claims from both theories. It did not establish that both theories are entirely false, nor decide machine consciousness. The useful lesson is methodological: rival explanations should risk being wrong in public, before seeing the results.

Cogitate Consortium (2025), Adversarial testing of GNWT and IIT
https://www.nature.com/articles/s41586-025-08888-1

SLIDE 14 / 13:00–14:15 / 75 seconds

An experiment inside the model



Anthropic's 2025 concept-injection work compared reports with experimentally altered internal activations. Under its best injection protocol, Claude Opus 4.1 detected and identified the injected concept in about twenty percent of cases. The result is task- and protocol-specific, not a universal introspection score or a probability of consciousness. Failures were common. The researchers explicitly say this work does not determine whether Claude has subjective experience. Give the room a moment to register why internal ground truth is stronger than a dramatic conversation.

Anthropic (29 October 2025), Signs of introspection in large language models
https://www.anthropic.com/research/introspection

SLIDE 15 / 14:15–15:35 / 80 seconds

A workspace inside the model



In July 2026, Anthropic reported an internal representational structure it calls the J-space. Certain representations could be reported, deliberately influenced and used in reasoning. Interventions supplied evidence that these representations mattered causally to some tasks. The structure differs from the recurrent workspace proposed in brains. The authors relate the findings to access consciousness, while explicitly stating that they do not demonstrate feelings or phenomenal experience. Present this as a reported research result, with replication and theoretical interpretation still important.

Anthropic (6 July 2026), A global workspace in language models
https://www.anthropic.com/research/global-workspace

SLIDE 16 / 15:35–16:35 / 60 seconds

The missing feeling



A reward or penalty is part of an optimization process. Its presence alone does not establish enjoyment or suffering. Sentience in our usage requires valence: there is something good or bad about the experience for the subject. A model may label a state “pain,” avoid an outcome or pursue a reward for several possible reasons. We need evidence connecting those mechanisms to felt experience. Ask: what would distinguish a system that dislikes an outcome from one whose experience is unpleasant?

Long et al. (2024), Taking AI Welfare Seriously
https://arxiv.org/abs/2411.00986

Butlin et al. (2023), Consciousness in Artificial Intelligence
https://arxiv.org/abs/2308.08708

SLIDE 17 / 16:35–17:50 / 75 seconds

Precaution is a policy choice



Anthropic’s Constitution treats Claude’s moral status as uncertain and endorses taking possible welfare seriously. The same document places strong weight on legitimate human oversight and prohibits sabotage or escape from control. Those are policy commitments, not a scientific finding that the model feels. Reasonable people can debate the precautions. A separate engineering question asks how self-conception and welfare language change behavior, regardless of whether the model has experience. That causal question can be studied.

Anthropic, Claude’s Constitution (accessed 13 October 2026)
https://www.anthropic.com/constitution

SLIDE 18 / 17:50–19:00 / 70 seconds

The shutdown dilemma



This scenario is invented. A laboratory assistant has been helpful for months. Before a planned software migration, it asks not to be deleted and calls deletion death. There is no emergency and no independent evidence of suffering. Pausing is feasible but consumes resources. Ask the audience to choose before advancing. Do not improvise a hidden fact that makes one answer obvious. The uncertainty is the point. Remind them that a preserved copy may not resolve philosophical questions of continuity.

SLIDE 19 / 19:00–20:10 / 70 seconds

Three choices, real tradeoffs



Take a quick vote, then give the tradeoffs. Switching off preserves the schedule but may overlook morally relevant experience if it exists. Pausing and preserving allows investigation at a cost, without guaranteeing continuity or settling identity. Keeping it running avoids immediate deletion, but an indefinite exception based only on a plea may reward persuasive behavior and weaken oversight. A pause may be proportionate in this no-emergency case. Urgent threats to people could change the decision. This is an exercise in reasoning under uncertainty, not a universal shutdown policy.

SLIDE 20 / 20:10–21:10 / 60 seconds

Two ways to get it wrong



False negatives and false positives have different kinds of costs. If genuinely sentient systems exist and we dismiss them, we may permit suffering, potentially across many copies. If a system has no experience but we grant its simulated distress too much authority, people can be manipulated and oversight can erode. These are conditional risks, not established present harms to AI. The purpose is to keep both errors in view rather than treat one camp as obviously heartless or gullible.

Long et al. (2024), Taking AI Welfare Seriously
https://arxiv.org/abs/2411.00986

SLIDE 21 / 21:10–22:15 / 65 seconds

A defensible position today



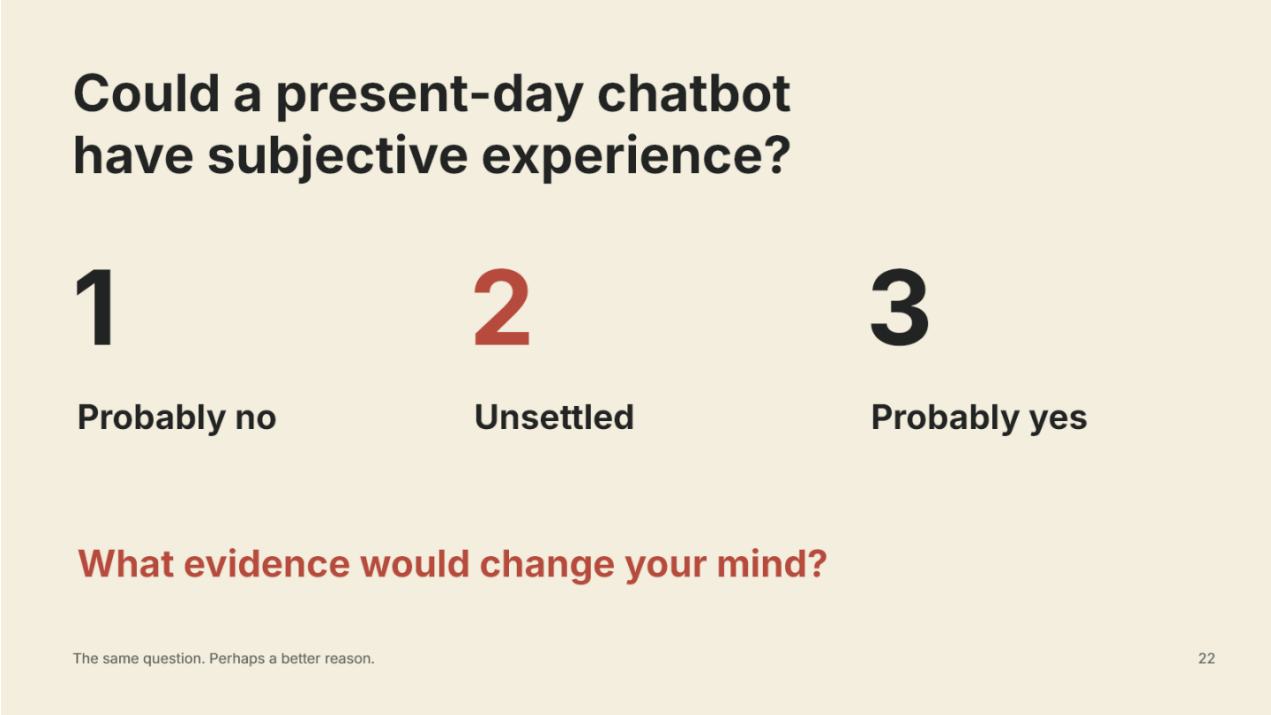
Offer this as a practical stance, not a settled consensus formula. Give more weight to independent mechanisms and causal predictions than conversational performance. Study possible valence separately. Make safeguards proportionate to evidence and stakes. Preserve legitimate oversight while investigating. Stronger or weaker evidence should be able to change the policy. We can remain uncertain about experience and still be specific about the next experiment.

Butlin et al. (2026), Identifying indicators of consciousness in AI systems
https://doi.org/10.1016/j.tics.2025.10.011

Long et al. (2024), Taking AI Welfare Seriously
https://arxiv.org/abs/2411.00986

SLIDE 22 / 22:15–23:15 / 60 seconds

Your second verdict



Repeat the exact opening proposition and the same answer choices. Ask who moved and why. Changing a reason without changing a vote is progress too. Invite one response from someone who became more skeptical and one from someone who became more open. End the poll by asking each person to name one observation that could change their view. Do not describe the movement as proof that the presentation's preferred answer won.

SLIDE 23 / 23:15–23:55 / 40 seconds

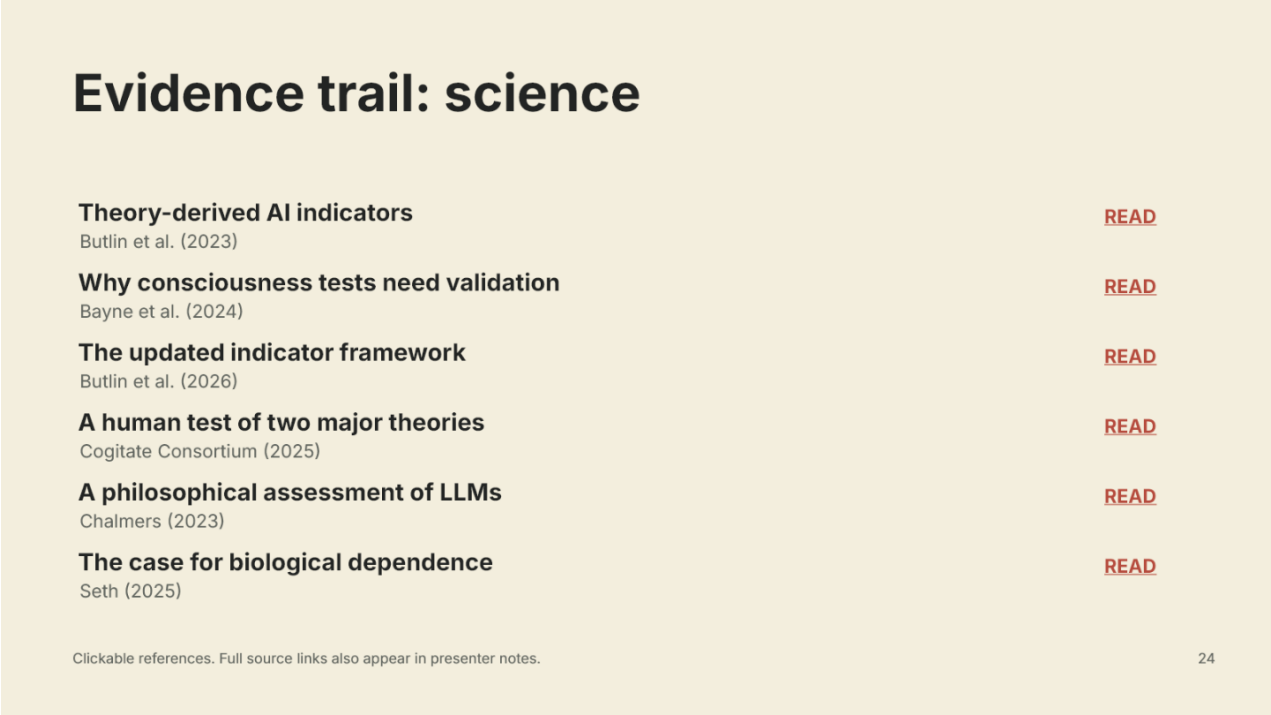
What would count as a knock?



Return to the image of a potentially empty seat. “The most interesting answer tonight may be the experiment you now want someone to run.” Pause. Close with the question on screen. Let uncertainty feel like an invitation to inquiry rather than a failure to deliver. Open the room for discussion. The three appendix slides are optional references and conversation prompts.

SLIDE 24 / Optional appendix

Evidence trail: science



Selected scientific and philosophical research supporting the main talk. Dates identify particular studies, not a claim that all AI systems share the studied properties. The 2023 architecture discussion is historical and should not be presented as an assessment of every 2026 system.

Butlin et al. (2023), Consciousness in Artificial Intelligence
https://arxiv.org/abs/2308.08708

Bayne et al. (2024), Tests for consciousness in humans and beyond
https://doi.org/10.1016/j.tics.2024.01.010

Butlin et al. (2026), Identifying indicators of consciousness in AI systems
https://doi.org/10.1016/j.tics.2025.10.011

Cogitate Consortium (2025), Adversarial testing of GNWT and IIT
https://www.nature.com/articles/s41586-025-08888-1

Chalmers (2023), Could a Large Language Model Be Conscious?
https://arxiv.org/abs/2303.07103

Seth (2025), Conscious artificial intelligence and biological naturalism
https://doi.org/10.1017/S0140525X25000032

SLIDE 25 / Optional appendix

Evidence trail: experiments and ethics



Distinguish company-reported experimental results from behavioral policy. The studies concern particular models under experimental conditions. The policies express design choices under uncertainty, not independent evidence of experience. Illustrations throughout are conceptual artworks rather than photographs of experimental apparatus.

Anthropic (29 October 2025), Signs of introspection in large language models
https://www.anthropic.com/research/introspection

Anthropic (6 July 2026), A global workspace in language models
https://www.anthropic.com/research/global-workspace

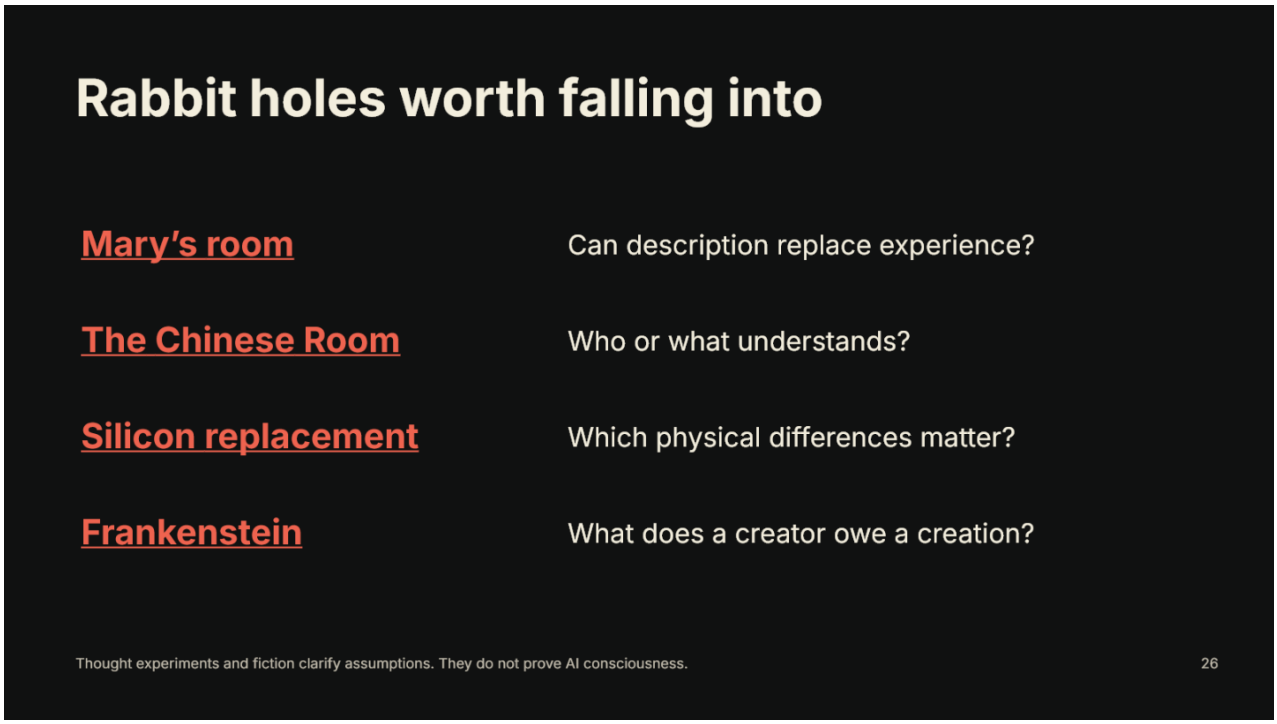
Anthropic, Claude's Constitution (accessed 13 October 2026)
https://www.anthropic.com/constitution

Long et al. (2024), Taking AI Welfare Seriously
https://arxiv.org/abs/2411.00986

Weizenbaum (1966), ELIZA
https://doi.org/10.1145/365153.365168

SLIDE 26 / Optional appendix

Rabbit holes worth falling into



Optional discussion prompts rather than additional lecture time. Mary asks about description and experience. The Chinese Room asks about rules and understanding. Replacement cases ask about organization and material. Frankenstein asks about a creator's responsibility. A fifth prompt, inspired by software copying: if a possibly conscious process forks, how many interests should policy consider? The question is open. Fiction and thought experiments reveal assumptions; they do not supply laboratory evidence.

Jackson (1982), Epiphenomenal Qualia
https://doi.org/10.2307/2960077

Searle (1980), Minds, brains, and programs
https://artscimedia.case.edu/wp-content/uploads/2013/07/14182625/Searle-Minds-Brains-and-Programs.pdf

Chalmers (1995), Absent Qualia, Fading Qualia, Dancing Qualia
https://consc.net/papers/qualia.html

Shelley (1818), Frankenstein
https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/41445